

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART TWO · CRAFT

CHAPTER 6 · SOUND

*Half of every film is something you hear, and most of it
you never notice.*

SUNSET BLVD.

Baby Driver · 2017 · 113 min · written and directed by Edgar
Wright · TriStar

*This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some
information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you
press play" and resume after the credits.*

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

Two crime films with gunfights, getaways and a man who will not stop coming. They sound nothing alike. No Country for Old Men has almost no music: wind, footsteps, a hum from a motel light, the hiss of a gas canister, and silence doing the work a score usually does.

Baby Driver is cut entirely to its soundtrack, with the car turns, the footsteps and even the gunshots landing on the beat of whatever is playing in the hero's ears. One takes the music away. The other makes everything music.

SUNSET BLVD.

BABY DRIVER

2017 · 113 min · written and directed by Edgar Wright · TriStar

A young getaway driver with ringing in his ears drowns it out with music and times every heist to the song in his headphones. Then he falls in love and tries to get out.

Why it is on the ballot. Where No Country strips the music away, this film is built on top of it. The songs were chosen before the film was shot, played on set, and the editing lands turns, footsteps and gunshots on the beat. It is a musical where nobody sings.

01

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

IT STARTED AS A MUSIC VIDEO

In 2003 Edgar Wright directed the video for Mint Royale's "Blue Song," in which Noel Fielding plays a getaway driver dancing in his car to the track while Nick Frost, Michael Smiley and Julian Barratt rob a bank — then complains that they were late. Wright: "It's somewhat similar to the opening scene of Baby Driver."

EVERYONE WORKED TO THE MUSIC

Wright: "We constantly piped the music over the sets so people could act to the song." Editor Jonathan Amos: "We had very specific points in every track where certain actions had to take place; we called these anchor points." Paul Machliss cut on location in real time so Wright could see the sequence assembling as they shot it.

THE OSCARS NOTICED THE CUTTING AND THE SOUND

Nominated for Film Editing (Machliss and Amos), Sound Editing and Sound Mixing, and it won the BAFTA for editing.

02

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THE OPENING HEIST

Everything is on the beat

"Bellbottoms" by The Jon Spencer Blues Explosion. Watch the wipers, the drumming on the wheel, the handbrake turns.

Why it matters: The film teaches you its rule immediately. If it moves, it moves on the beat.

THE COFFEE RUN

One take, and read the walls

Baby walks to get coffee in a single unbroken shot to Bob & Earl's "Harlem Shuffle." Watch the graffiti and signage he passes: "Move," "Right," "Whole Lotta," "Soul."

Why it matters: The lyrics are painted on the street. The sound is being turned into picture.

WHEN THE MUSIC STOPS

Listen to the ringing

Every time the earbuds come out you hear what he hears: a high whine. Sound designer Julian Slater pitched the tinnitus to the music on either side of it, so the hum belongs to whatever song just ended.

Why it matters: The film gives you his point of view through sound. The music is not style, it is how he gets through the day.

THE SHOOTOUT

Guns on the beat

One gunfight is cut to "Tequila" — the Button Down Brass version, not the Champs. The actors had to learn their gunfire like a percussion part, because on set the shots drown out the track.

Why it matters: It is thrilling, and slightly disturbing. Ask whether turning violence into rhythm makes it more fun or harder to watch.

03

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

He samples his own life

Baby secretly records the people around him and remixes their voices into tracks on cassette. The hero is doing what the film does: cutting the world to a beat.

OPEN

The quiet scenes are in sign language

Baby's deaf foster father Joseph is played by CJ Jones, and their conversations happen in sign. The film's only real silences are the moments of love.

OPEN

Every sound was tempo-mapped

Slater's team worked out the tempo of the effects themselves so they could be stretched and pitched to sit with the songs: "we knew exactly what the corresponding tempo of those sounds had to be."

01 Baby Driver is cut to its songs. Did that make the violence more fun, or more uncomfortable?

02 When the music cuts out, what do you hear, and what does it tell you about Baby?

03 No Country has almost no score. Baby Driver never stops. Which film used sound better?

Where to watch

Find it here → [Baby Driver on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: Rolling Stone · Post Perspective · CineMontage · A Sound Effect

THE LESSON

HEARD, NOT NOTICED

THREE SOVIET DIRECTORS SAW IT COMING

In 1928, as synchronised sound arrived, Sergei Eisenstein, Vsevolod Pudovkin and Grigori Alexandrov published a short “Statement on Sound.” They warned that sound would be used for “talking films” — recorded theatre — which would destroy the art of the cut, and argued for the opposite: “Only a contrapuntal use of sound in relation to the visual montage piece will afford a new potentiality of montage development and perfection.”

HOLLYWOOD DID THE OPPOSITE

The studios synchronised everything — every line, every door, every footstep — and composers like Max Steiner laid a lush orchestral score underneath that followed the feeling of every scene. The working rule became: the audience should feel the music, not hear it. A good score was one nobody noticed.

THE RULE GOT ITS NAME LATER

In 1987 the scholar Claudia Gorbman set out the principles of classical Hollywood scoring in *Unheard Melodies*. One of them is inaudibility: music is not meant to be heard consciously. She was describing a habit, not prescribing one, but the phrase stuck, and the habit is still the default in most films you watch.

THREE WAYS A FILM CAN USE SOUND

ONE

MATCH IT

Sound follows the picture and the score follows the feeling. You never think about it.

Almost everything

TWO

TAKE IT AWAY

Little or no score, so small sounds and silence carry the tension.

No Country for Old Men · A Quiet Place · The Birds

THREE

LET IT DRIVE

The music comes first and the picture is cut to it.

Baby Driver · Whiplash · Guardians of the Galaxy

The third one is rare: it requires obtaining song rights before a frame is shot.

IN THE SCENE VS. IN THE SCREEN



Diegetic sound has a source inside the world: the radio playing, the bird through the open window, the man's own voice. He could switch any of it off. Non-diegetic sound is laid over that world from outside it — a score played by musicians who are not in the room and never will be. To tell them apart, ask whether anything in the shot could stop the sound.

The frame is the border, which is why *Baby Driver* is such a strange case: its songs are diegetic, playing in Baby's earbuds, and they do the job of a score at the same time.

Room tone is a third thing again — the sound of a space with nobody talking. Every set records it, and *No Country for Old Men* is practically built out of it.

WHY THESE FILMS

This closes Part Two. The frame decides what you see, the cut decides when, and sound decides how it feels. One film proves how loud silence is. The other proves a film can be edited like a song.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from Carter Burwell's project notes, Designing Sound, Criterion, Rolling Stone, CineMontage and the Academy's records. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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